

The Political Economy of Second Breakfast

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2026-08-05

Visitors to the Shire reliably make the same two observations: the food is excellent, and nobody seems to work. The first is true. The second is a measurement error, and the error is instructive.

1 Six meals as infrastructure

The hobbit meal schedule — breakfast, second breakfast, elevenses, luncheon, afternoon tea, dinner, and supper where obtainable — is usually treated as appetite. It is better understood as *institutional* infrastructure. Each meal is a standing, scheduled occasion for information exchange: crop prices at elevenses, labour-sharing arrangements over luncheon, credit (in the form of remembered favours) extended across the tea table.

The Shire has no banks, no courts worth mentioning, and no police beyond a dozen Shirriffs concerned chiefly with stray livestock. What it has instead is contract enforcement by reputation, cleared six times daily. As I argued in my study of wartime provisioning¹, the region's logistics run on trust; second breakfast is where the trust is manufactured.

2 The measurement problem

Standard labour accounting counts hours at visible work. It therefore records the Shire as a low-effort economy, which would puzzle anyone who has seen the harvest brought in — or seen the Rohirrim wrestle with the opposite problem², a society that counts martial labour meticulously and wastes half its supply.

The general lesson: institutions that look like leisure may be doing the work your formal institutions aren't. Audit what the long lunch *produces* before you abolish it.

3 A note on exits

It is sometimes objected that the system only works because nobody leaves. This is broadly right, and what happens when the talented *do* leave is taken up in Elrond's account of the westward migration³ — a rather larger version of the same problem.

¹[../supply-chains-of-middle-earth/index.qmd](#)

²[../shieldmaidens-labour-market/index.qmd](#)

³[../grey-havens-exit/index.qmd](#)